the moves came as a surprise to Chinese forces and led to perhaps the most tense moment in India–China relations since the 1960s. India leveraged its gains to broker a mutual disengagement at Pangong Tso in early 2021. [40] Over the next few years, similar agreements were negotiated by military commanders at the other major friction points. [41] But the large-scale armed deployment of Chinese and Indian forces in close proximity to one another and improved infrastructure fundamentally altered the LAC, making it much more volatile. Major conflict, which might previously have required days or weeks of preparation, could now break out instantly.

India was not alone in facing the brunt of Chinese assertiveness following the outbreak of the coronavirus pandemic, suggesting that the causes were not necessarily India-specific. In May 2020, China's National People's Congress advanced a national security law for Hong Kong with wide extra-territorial implications in a manner that undermined prior commitments to the region's autonomy and the notion of 'one country, two systems'. Australia's government and businesses suffered a major cyberattack attributed to China, as well as trade restrictions. Chinese territorial claims in Bhutan were advanced in areas that had not featured previously in negotiations. Chinese vessels intimidated Malaysian and Vietnamese shipping in the South China Sea, and Chinese military activity in Japan's exclusive economic zone and Taiwan's airspace saw an increase. Diplomatically, China's 'wolf warriors' openly criticized US, European, British, and Brazilian leaders. China also detained and charged two Canadians with espionage. [42]

The deterioration of China's relations with India—along with other Indo–Pacific countries—contributed to the elevation and restructuring of the Quad immediately following Joe Biden's assumption of the US presidency in January 2021. The group comprising India, the United States, Japan, and Australia agreed to meet annually at the leadership level and established working groups on health, climate change, and critical and emerging technologies. [43] The logic was to deliver public goods to the Indo–Pacific in a coordinated manner without heightening security tensions. In time, the number of working groups and deliverables proliferated to include